



SAGE HAVEN

Understanding the Past, Building Futures

2026 Annual
Report



Sage Haven Society operates within the traditional territory of the Hupačasath First Nation and the Tseshaht First Nation, within Nuuchah-nulth territory. We are grateful for the opportunity to live, work, and provide services on these lands, and we recognize the ongoing relationship between the Nuuchah-nulth peoples and this territory.



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LETTER FROM THE CHAIR OF THE BOARD

Caroline Melville

Shortly after joining the Board of Directors in December, I accepted the responsibility of serving as Board Chair. This was a period of significant organizational change for the society, but I had a clear understanding of the Board's responsibility to protect Sage Haven's mission, exercise independent oversight, and support its long-term strength.

Before I joined the Board, the transition from longtime Executive Director Ellen Froot to Janine Fraser had already begun. Tragically, this transition was cut short by Ellen's sudden passing in October, a profound loss for our entire community. This year also brought significant Board renewal, including the departure of several long-serving directors and the addition of two new members: Melissa Gus of Tseshah First Nation and Chelsea Belyk, a professional accountant who brings valuable financial expertise. We paused active recruitment over the summer and will resume this fall.

I extend my sincere appreciation to my fellow directors, including those who served during different periods of the year. Their ethical stewardship and willingness to undertake difficult governance responsibilities have been invaluable, keeping decisions focused on organizational integrity and the long-term interests of the community.

The relationship between a Board and an Executive Director must be grounded in trust, candour, and respect for distinct roles. As Chair, I prioritized a consistent governance relationship with Janine so that organizational matters could be raised promptly and decisions advanced with appropriate

oversight. The Board recognizes Janine's sustained leadership this year, her commitment to service continuity, transparent funder communication, and strengthened organizational systems was evident during an exceptionally demanding period.

I also want to acknowledge the managerial and staff changes that occurred this year, and the additional strain this placed on the Sage Haven team. I have the utmost respect for our dedicated managers, staff, and volunteers, whose trauma-informed, survivor-centred work is demanding, essential, and deeply consequential for our community.

Looking ahead, the Board remains committed to supporting an environment where this work can continue safely and sustainably: strengthening workforce stability, sustaining service delivery, and stewarding resources responsibly, while representing Sage Haven Society visibly in our community. We move forward with clarity and an unwavering commitment to our enduring purpose: Understanding the past and building futures.

Caroline Melville

LETTER FROM THE EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR

Janine Fraser



The past year was one of significant change and renewal for Sage Haven Society. It required clear priorities, careful stewardship, and a sustained focus on organizational strength and service continuity. My responsibility remained clear throughout: support the organization, strengthen accountability, and ensure our essential services remained firmly centred on the needs of survivors.

I directed work to clarify organizational roles, enhance financial and administrative oversight, and improve operational coordination, work that established greater consistency and strengthened the foundation required for effective governance. Strategic planning also advanced this year, focused on team stability, organizational capacity, and a disciplined framework for long-term execution.

Open, timely communication with funders and community partners remained integral to our approach, and I'm grateful for the confidence and shared commitment they've shown Sage Haven. We also moved forward under a new collective agreement, an important part of our continued commitment to a stable, respectful workplace.

Most importantly, our mission remained at the centre of every decision. Staff and volunteers continued to provide complex, trauma-informed, survivor-centred services to women and children affected by intimate partner violence, gender-based violence, and sexual violence, ensuring survivors received safe, respectful support when they needed it most.

I want to speak directly to what that dedication

looks like. Every day, the people of Sage Haven are unsung heroes: answering a crisis call at midnight, sitting beside a survivor in her hardest moment, walking a child through the worst thing they've ever known. Their work saves lives. It keeps women and children safe. Whatever this year asked of us, this never wavered.

As someone new to both British Columbia and Port Alberni, I'm deeply grateful for the welcome and support extended to me, and to the current and former members of our Board of Directors, whose ethical stewardship and thoughtful direction have been invaluable throughout a demanding year.

This year's work has positioned Sage Haven Society to move forward with clearer accountabilities, stronger systems, and renewed direction. Further work remains, as it does in every organization committed to continuous improvement, but our foundation is strong. We remain grounded, as always, in the purpose that has guided this Society throughout its history: Understanding the past and building futures.

Janine Fraser



Ellen Frood

Executive Director, 2016–2026



In Memory of

a Decade of Service

For ten years, Ellen Frood led Sage Haven Society with a steady hand and a clear sense of purpose. Her tenure was defined by a deep, unwavering commitment to the women and children this organization exists to serve, and by the belief that safety shouldn't end the moment someone leaves crisis behind.

That belief became Second Stage Housing. Ellen was the driving force behind establishing this program, giving women and children fleeing intimate partner violence, gender-based violence, and sexual violence the stability and longer-term support they need to truly rebuild their lives, not

just survive the moment, but build what comes after. It stands today as one of the clearest expressions of what she believed this organization owed the people it serves. Ellen passed away suddenly this year, a profound loss for everyone who knew her and for the organization she gave a decade of her life to. Her absence is deeply felt across every program she helped build and every person she helped lead. We are certain she would want this work, and this Society, to keep moving forward with the same care she brought to it.

We honour her memory, and we carry her legacy forward.



We Also Remember Kim Donovan

Later in the year, Sage Haven Society was saddened by the death of Kim Donovan, who supported the organization's resource-development work as a contractor. We acknowledge Kim's contribution with respect and gratitude, and extend our sincere condolences to his family, friends, and colleagues.

Our Mission

In collaboration with our community, we provide safe spaces and supportive services for women and those affected by intimate partner violence, gender based violence and sexual violence.

Our Vision

The Alberni Valley and region will be safe nurturing place where everyone lives free from the effects of intimate relationship and gender-based violence.

Our Values



Supportive

We meet people where they are at without judgement , adapting services to peoples needs.



Empowering

We center client choice and build on strengths



Respecting diversity and Culture

We honor identified and practice cultural humility



Compassion

We act with empathy, kindness and ensure stigma free care



Education

We share knowledge to prevent harm and to strengthen safety



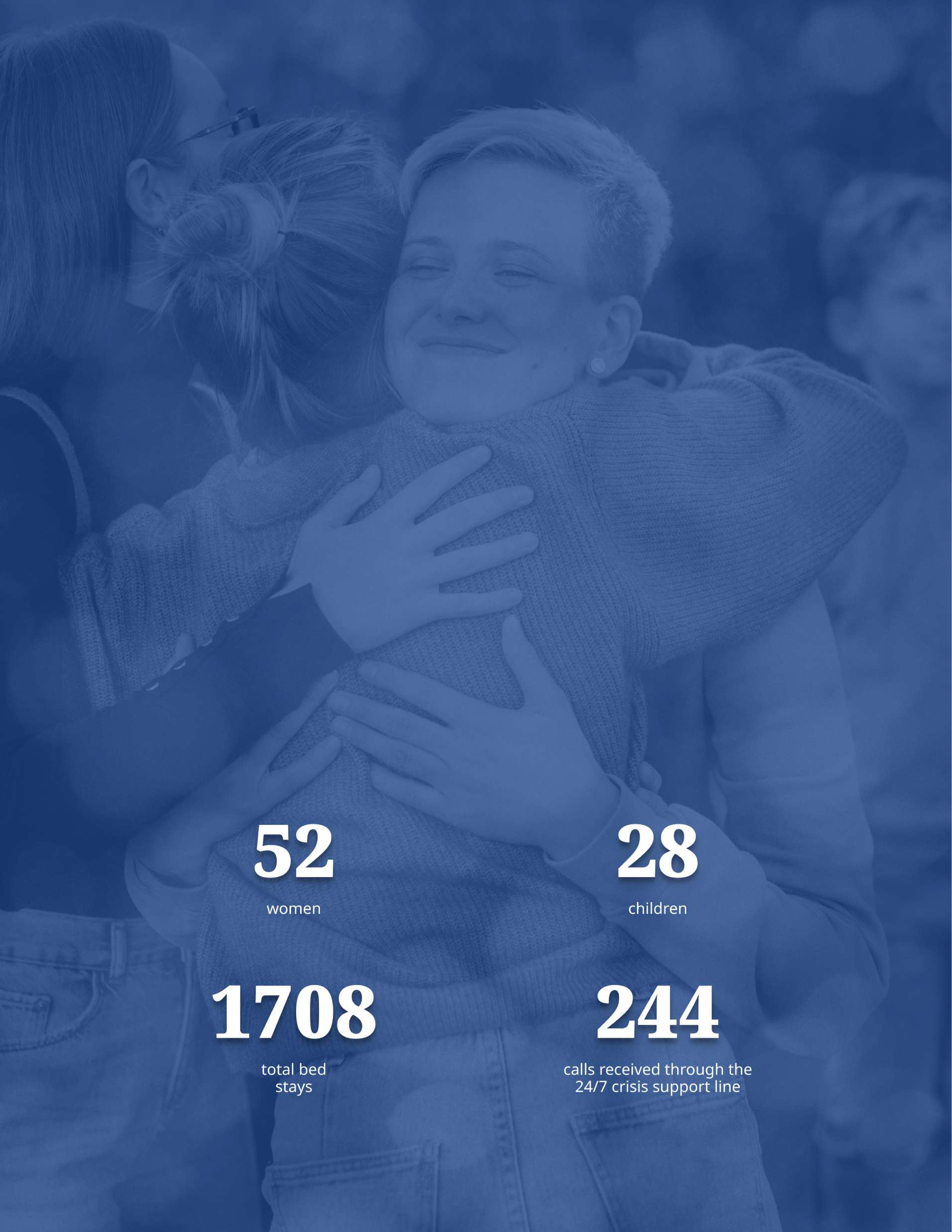
Progressive

We listen, learn, improve continuously, together



Transparency

We communicate openly, do what we say, and steward our resources wisely for lasting benefit



52

women

28

children

1708

total bed
stays

244

calls received through the
24/7 crisis support line

FIRST STAGE

Transition Housing

Our Transition House has provided emergency shelter to women and children fleeing inter-partner violence and gender-based violence and sexual violence since 1972, 54 years ago. BC Housing funds 11 beds across a five-bedroom home, which includes a family room and a pet room, so that no one has to choose between safety and the animal they can't leave behind. The location is kept confidential to protect the women and children who stay there.

Providing emergency shelter to those in crisis for

54
Years



Support Worker, Thea Berg, with survivors during a BBQ



“Because of the support I received at Sage Haven, I was able to accomplish exactly what second-stage housing is designed to help women achieve. In a remarkably short period of time, I secured meaningful employment, found a home of my own, and began building a new life in Port Alberni. Today, I am thriving. I have a management position that I truly love, a safe place to call home, and a community where I feel like I belong. Moving to Port Alberni has been one of the best decisions of my life, and it would not have happened without Alana's belief in me and the support of everyone at Sage Haven.”

~Past Program Participant

26

unique women

28

children

5

pets



Garden Club continues at Second Stage



Pepper plant grown in the Second Stage garden

SECOND STAGE

WIIKŠAḤIQU?İŁ Housing

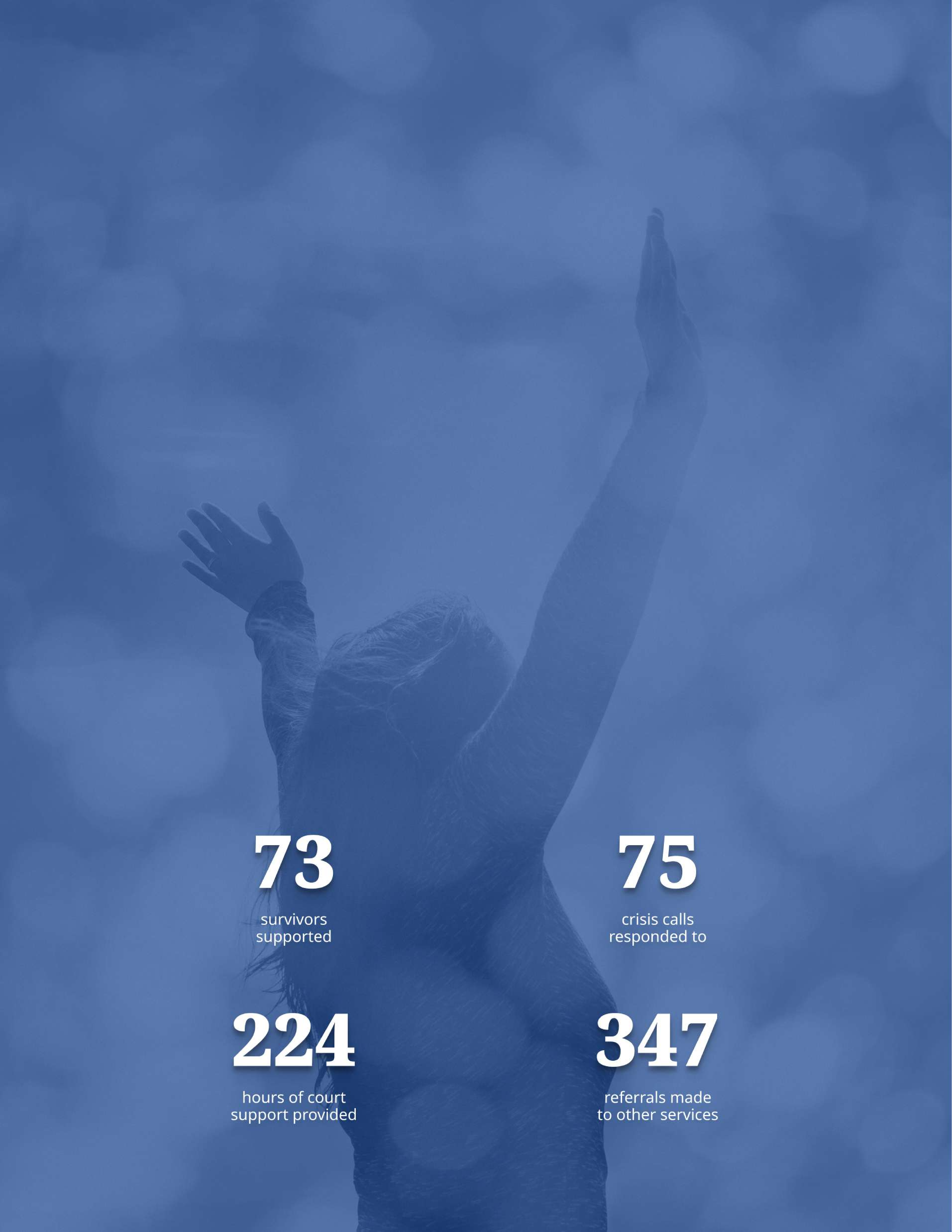
Wiikšahiqu?ił, meaning "a safe place" in Nuu-chah-nulth, opened in spring 2024. The facility offers 22 units, including 12 studios, 4 one-bedroom, 2 two-bedroom, and 2 three-bedroom units, for women and children moving through a six to eighteen month stay. All rents are geared to income, keeping the housing affordable for a population that's often starting over with very little.

This past year we prioritized our gardening club where food sustainability and connection with each other was key.

In their own words

"I first off want to begin by thanking you guys for all your help. It was a wonderful experience, everyone was so welcoming and helpful. I was in a bad situation with nowhere to go and two children to take care of on my own. Second stage gave me hope when I had none, and gave me time to heal, resources and help that I needed to start over and survive on my own."

Program Participant



73

survivors
supported

75

crisis calls
responded to

224

hours of court
support provided

347

referrals made
to other services

**SARP is confidential
and always meets the
survivors where they
are at.**

SEXUAL ASSAULT RESPONSE PROGRAM

SARP

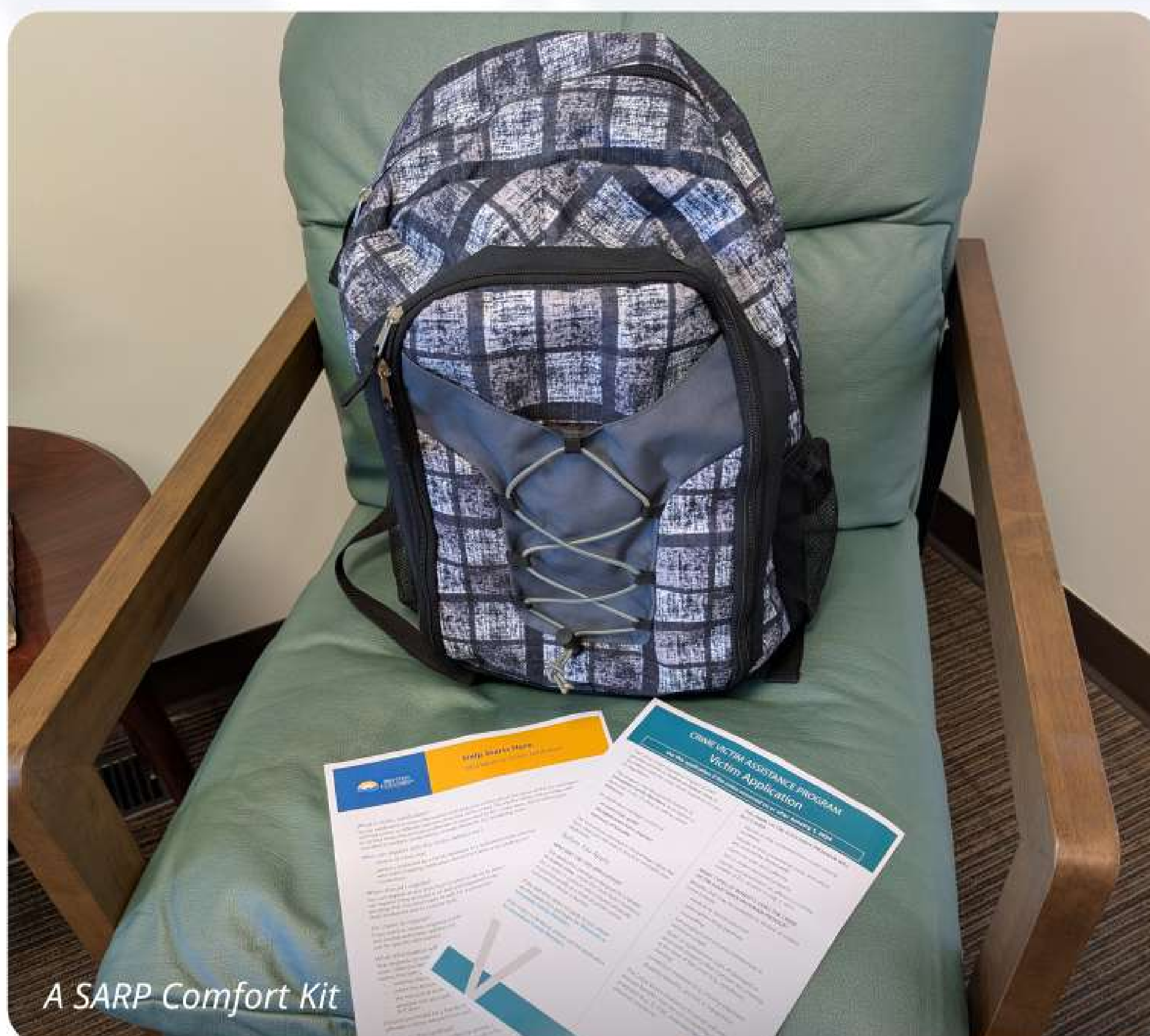
This work asks something different of the people who do it. A survivor doesn't walk through our door on their schedule, they arrive on the worst night of their life, and our job in that moment isn't to fix anything, it's to make sure they're not alone in it.

"After one particularly difficult call-out, our SARP coordinator and I sat down together to debrief. She told me, 'I will never un-see what happened.' We sat together, sometimes in silence, sometimes with me just listening. That's the part of this work that doesn't make it into statistics: the people who show up for survivors need somewhere to put down what they've carried, too," recounts Janine Fraser, the Society's new Executive Director.

What stays constant is how we show up: trained from both a trauma-informed and Indigenous-based perspective, working alongside the Forensic Nurse Examiner program so a survivor never has to explain themselves twice. We stay for as long as it takes, from the first phone call through a courtroom months or years later. Every survivor gets to decide what healing looks like for them. We just make sure they don't have to walk it alone.

Priorities for 2026/2027

- Keep our comfort kits stocked and ready. Demand was high this year, and every survivor accompanied to hospital needs one waiting for them.
- Recruit and onboard more volunteers. The need in this community is real, and it's growing.



A SARP Comfort Kit



Contents of a SARP Comfort Kit

A blue-tinted photograph of three young women standing in a field of tall grass, smiling and looking towards the camera. The image serves as the background for the entire graphic.

4,727

people served

1,730

clothing/donation
items distributed

354

food support instances

2,566

first nations
individuals served

COMMUNITY RESOURCE

Drop In Centre

This year, our Drop-In Centre paused, not because the need went away, but because our space required some attention. A necessary renovation gave us the chance to step back and ask a harder question: who is this space actually for?

We asked our clients, their children and our stakeholders who've stood beside this program for years. What we heard was consistent, and that matters to us. Our mandate has always been to serve women and children surviving intimate partner violence, gender-based violence, and sexual violence, and we're using this pause to make sure every square foot of this space reflects that,

not what it drifted toward, but what it was always meant to be.

We're proud of what the Drop-In Centre has offered this community, and just as proud of the harder conversations that got us here. When we reopen, it will be with a clearer purpose and a program that genuinely fills the gap our clients told us they needed filled.

Re-opening

2027
Spring



Two long time Drop-in patrons picking plants to make some gorgeous planters

YOUTH & ADULT Outreach Services

Not everyone who needs support walks through our door on their own. Outreach exists for the people who wouldn't otherwise find their way to us, whether that's an adult navigating a difficult relationship without knowing where to turn, or a young person who isn't sure their situation even has a name yet.

Our Adult Outreach team provided judgment-free emotional and crisis support along with advocacy throughout the year, meeting people where they were rather than waiting for a crisis point.

Our Youth Outreach team stayed active in local high schools on a regular basis, showing up consistently so that young people would recognize a familiar, trusted face if or when they needed one. That presence did two things at once: it gave youth real education about healthy relationships, and it created an opening for the ones who weren't confident enough to ask on their own, whether they were questioning something in their own relationship or worried about a friend's.

66

new outreach referrals

720km

travelled to clients

95

safety plans completed

A blue-tinted background image showing the silhouettes of children with their hands raised in the air, suggesting a group activity or a moment of celebration.

269

counselling sessions

69

new referrals

4X

wait times increase
since beginning of year

CHILDREN'S SUPPORTIVE COUNSELLING

PEACE

For a child exposed to intimate partner violence, healing has to start somewhere. PEACE is where we believe it should: a safe space just for them, to talk about what they've seen and felt, without having to carry any of it alone.

Every child who comes to PEACE learns the same essential truth: gender-based violence is never acceptable, and it was never their fault. Their only job is to be a child.

Through counselling, children learn to name their big feelings and find what works for them to express their needs, often for the first time in their lives. One child arrived shut down, convinced he was a bad kid and that everything wrong around him was somehow his fault. He had no confidence in what he could do. In a short time, working with Lego for the first time in his life, he built the most extravagant structure, along with craft after craft. He learned he had real abilities. He learned none of what happened was his fault. He learned he's actually pretty cool. Another young person came to PEACE as a teenager and has since found the confidence and self-esteem to pursue post-secondary education, with medical school as the goal. It's hard to overstate the distance between the young person who first walked through our doors and the one working toward that future now.

Parents are part of this too. We help them understand what their child may be experiencing and how to support them at home, so the work doesn't stop when the session ends.

Referrals come from every direction: schools, doctors' offices, dentists, and community partners across the Alberni Valley, which tells us something important, the adults around these kids are watching, and they know where to send them.

COMMUNITY BASED

Victim Support Services

Community-Based Victim Services acts as an advocate and liaison between survivors and the police, prosecutors, and social service agencies they must navigate, often at the most vulnerable and overwhelming point in their lives. This service exists so that a survivor's voice is heard and their needs are met, without having to fight for it on their own.

In practice, this support touches nearly every step of a survivor's path through the justice system: preparing for court orientations, trials, and sentencing; sitting alongside clients through RCMP interviews and judicial hearings; keeping them informed as investigations and court proceedings move forward, often the hardest part to face alone. The coordinator also helps clients complete the paperwork that stands between them and protection: Protection Orders, Victim Impact Statements, Crime Victim Assistance applications, and Victim Safety Unit registration, along with third-party reports for survivors of sexual assault who aren't ready to report on their own.

Sexual assault trials heard by the BC Supreme Court have nearly tripled in five years, from 43 in 2021 to 118 in 2025 (Supreme Court of British Columbia, Annual Report 2025). For survivors already navigating one of the hardest processes they'll ever face, that kind of demand on an overburdened court system makes steady, informed advocacy even more essential, not less.

166

new clients supported

235

active caseload (+46%)

534

safety plans completed

122

new referrals (women)

462

counselling sessions

45

active caseload (+67%)

STOPPING THE VIOLENCE

STV

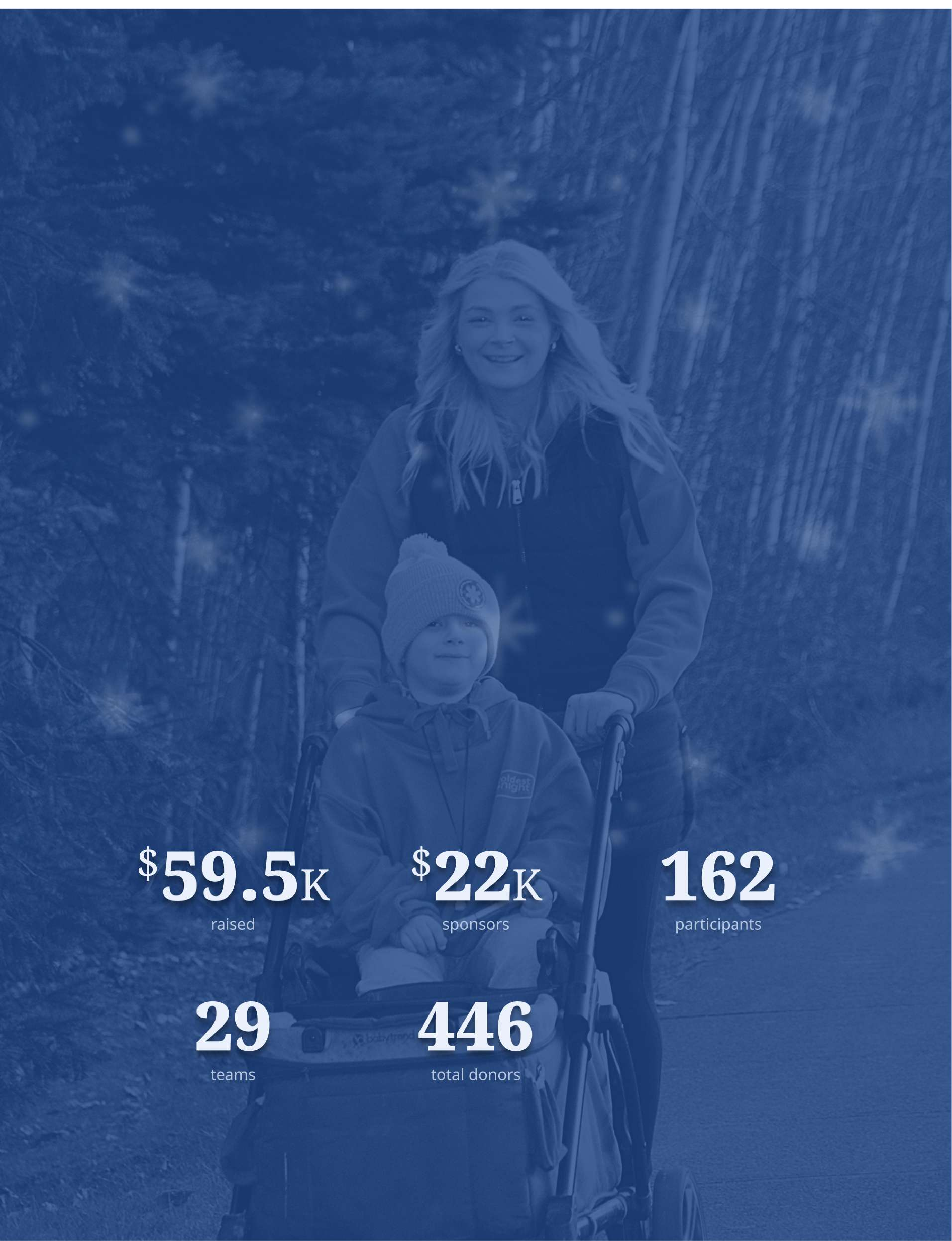
Our women's counselling programs offer individual and group support to self-identified women aged 19 and older who have experienced intimate partner violence or remain at risk of it. These programs give women a safe space to explore their experiences, build on their strengths, and take real steps toward healing and reclaiming their lives, learning to recognize the dynamics of abuse, build a safety plan, and develop the skills, resources, and connections that carry them forward. For many women, this counselling is the first place they've ever been able to say what happened out loud, without needing to justify or explain it.

Two groups sit at the heart of this program:

Making Connections offers a safe space for women with experiences of abuse and violence to explore, understand, and find support together, often the first step toward feeling less alone in what they've lived through.

Rebuilding Lives is offered to women who are no longer in abusive relationships, and includes culturally relevant materials and healing practices drawn from our First Nations communities, supporting women as they move from surviving into building a life of their own choosing.

Getting started is simple by design: women can self-refer directly, completing a short form at our office or downloading and submitting it themselves, no outside referral needed to begin.



\$59.5k

raised

\$22k

sponsors

162

participants

29

teams

446

total donors

coldest *night OF THE YEAR

Together we exceed our fundraising goal by

20%

Every February, our community steps out into the cold together, walking to raise funds and awareness for women and children facing violence.

Together, we raised \$59.5K, well past our \$50K goal, with support from 446 donors and \$22K in sponsorship from local businesses that believe in this work as much as we do. Every dollar raised goes directly toward keeping our doors open for the women and children who need them.

We're deeply grateful to our sponsors, along with every local business, volunteer, and dignitary who made the day possible. Special thanks to Hupacasath First Nations, and to our many community partners for their generosity along the route.

Because of everyone who walked, donated, and cheered from the sidewalk, we exceeded our fundraising goal and can keep building safety for women and children facing violence, one cold February morning at a time.



Thank you to our Sponsors & Partners



Administration

Administration is the quiet backbone that keeps everything else running: coordinating daily operations, managing financial processes, and keeping records organized so staff can stay focused on the people they serve.

This past year, that work went into strengthening internal systems and processes across the Society, along with supporting fundraising and community initiatives through donor record management, communications, and the countless details that bring a campaign or event together. It's work that rarely gets seen directly, but everything else depends on it.

"Behind every program, every survivor we support, and every family that finds safety here, there's a team keeping the lights on, the doors open, and the building sound. I'm endlessly grateful for the work our administration and facilities staff do, often unseen, but never unfelt."

Janine Fraser
Executive Director



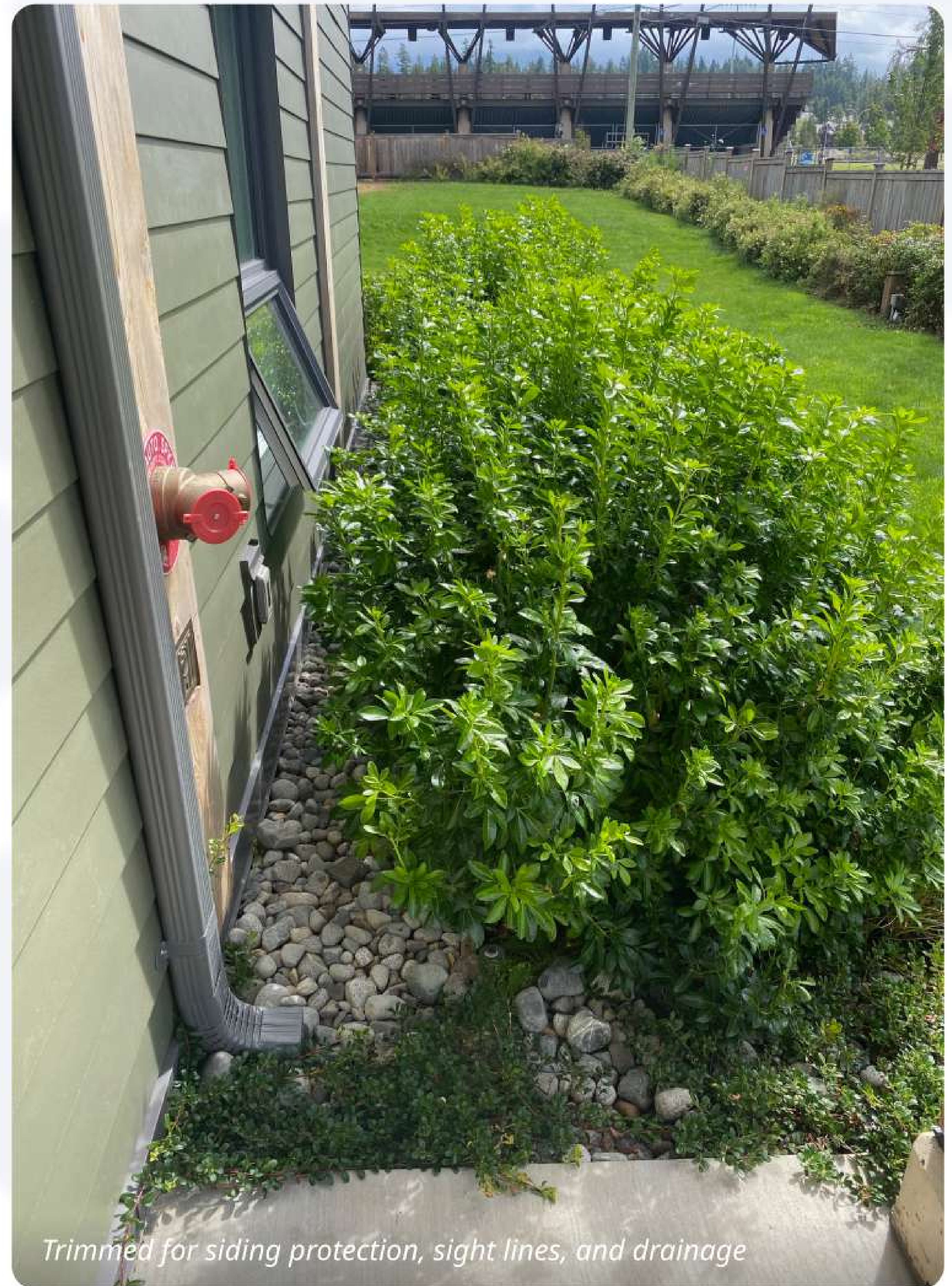
Every detail is meticulously planned and executed by our Admin Team



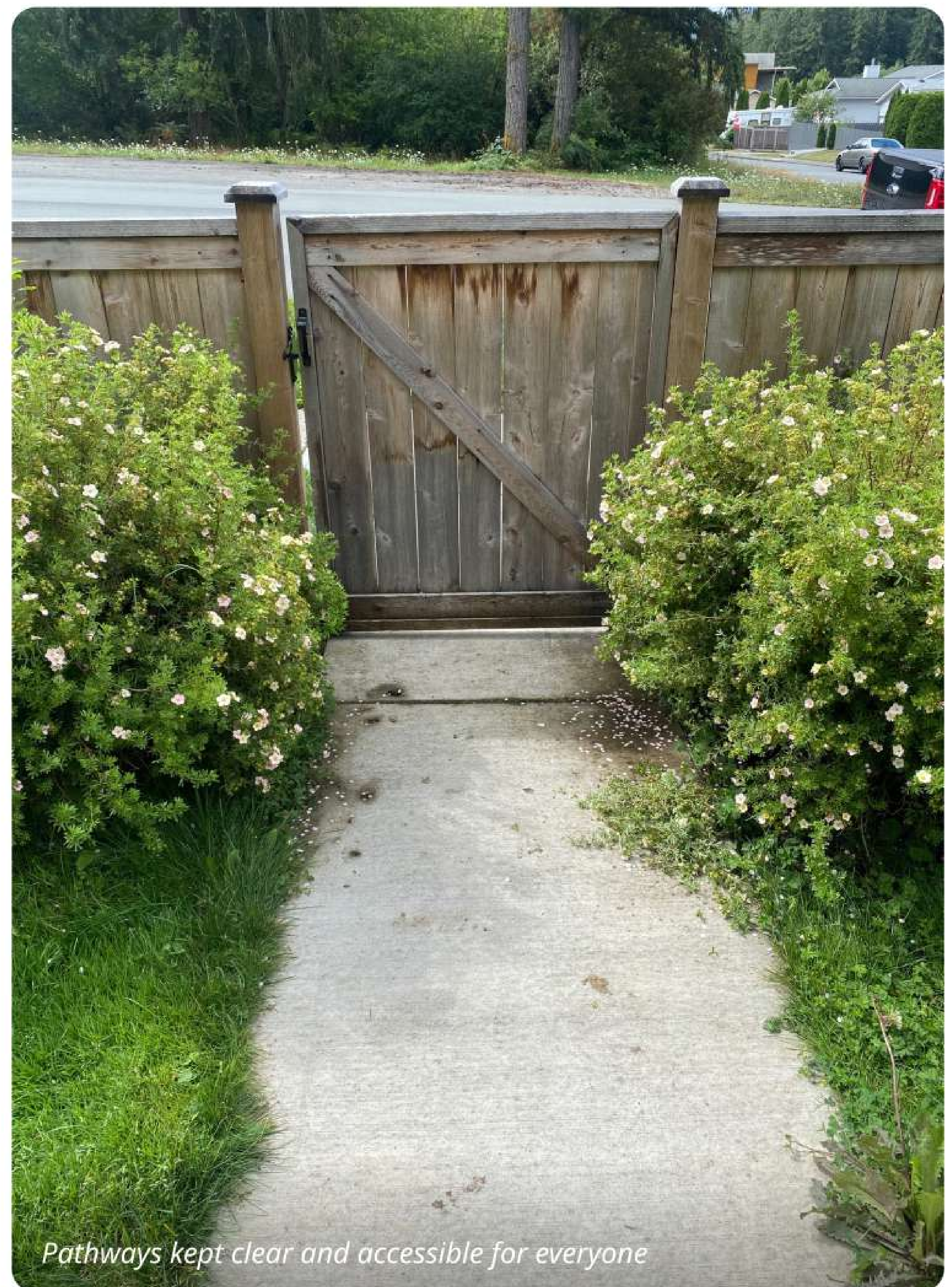
Event set up for Coldest Night of the Year 2026

Facilities & Maintenance

Behind every safe space is a great deal of planning and work to keep it maintained. This year, our facilities team kept all three sites clean, secure, and running, from daily sanitizing and floor care to lawn maintenance, irrigation upkeep, and keeping storm drains and heat pump units clear for safety and function. Preventive maintenance stayed steady across the board: gutters, HVAC filters, fire suppression checks, and monthly fire alarm testing. Looking ahead, the main office is getting a facelift, new security cameras are already in place, and fire suppression upgrades at Second Stage are underway with Troy Life and Fire.



Trimmed for siding protection, sight lines, and drainage



Pathways kept clear and accessible for everyone



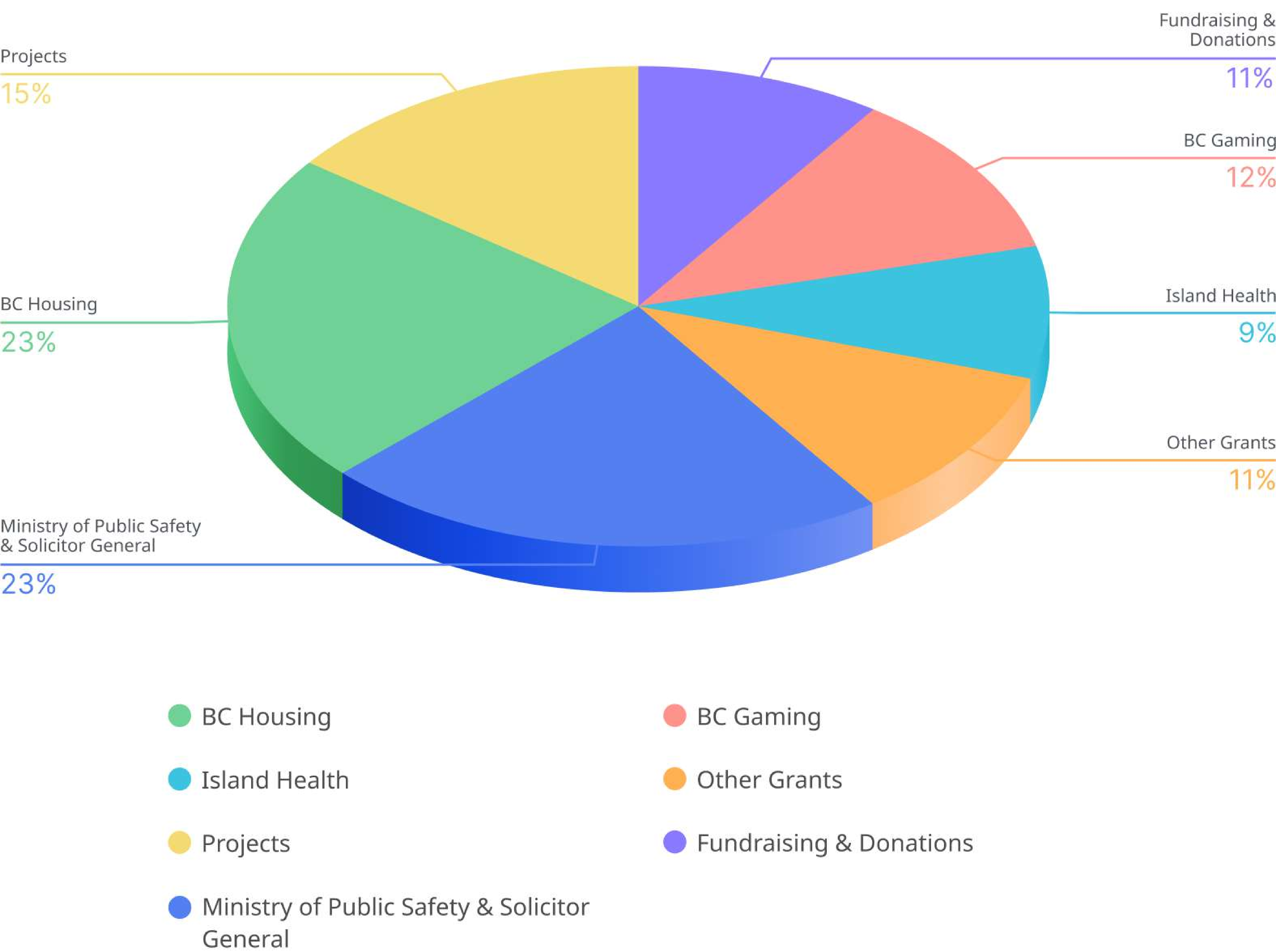
Kept clear so heat pump units can operate safely.

Revenue

Sage Haven's programs are made possible through a diversified mix of government contracts, health authority partnerships, and gaming and grant funding, supplemented by community fundraising and donations. This diversification means no single funder carries the full weight of our work, which allows us to keep serving women, children, and families even as any one funding source shifts from year to year.

BC Housing and the Ministry of Public Safety and

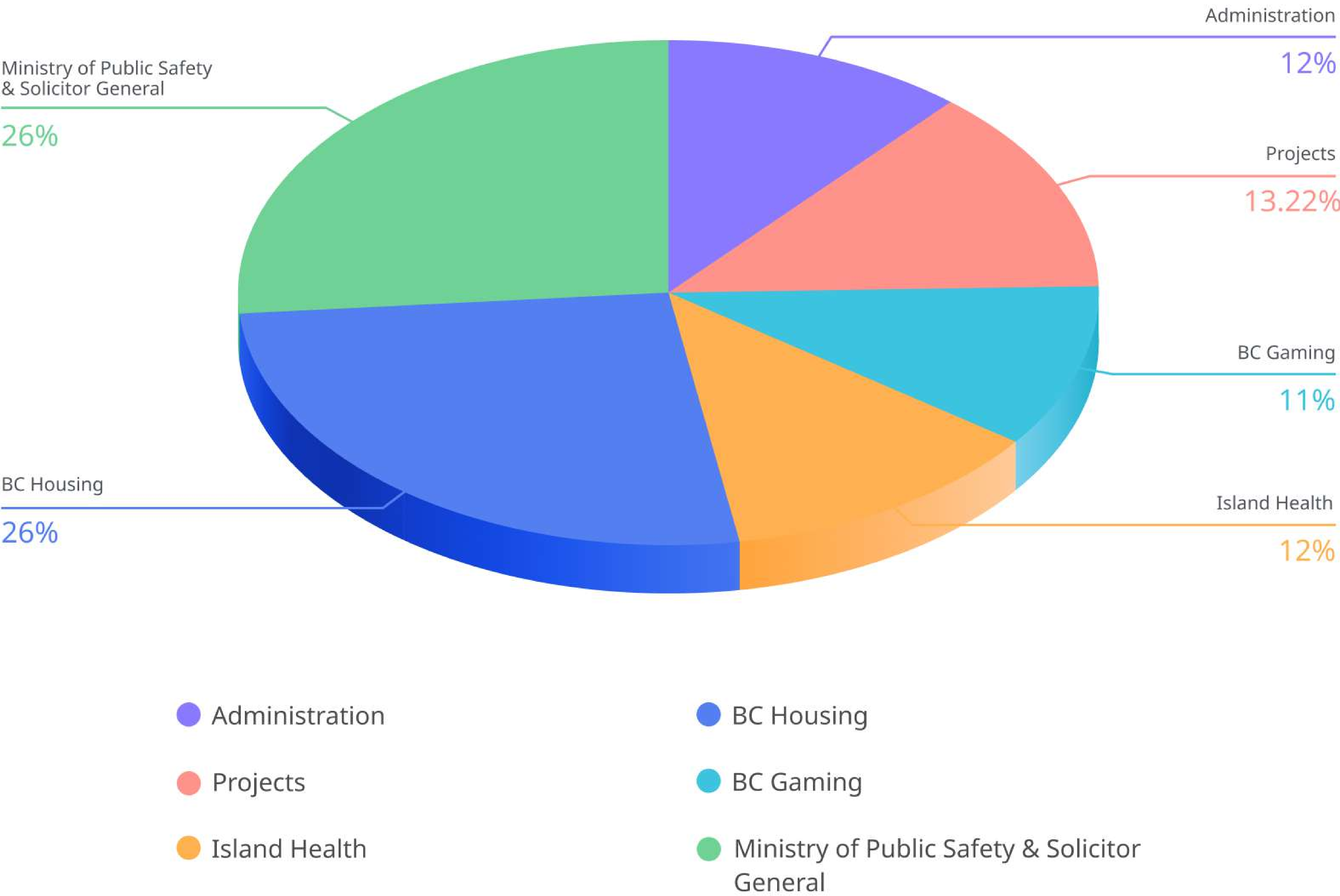
Solicitor General remain our two largest funding partners, reflecting their long-standing investment in both our housing programs and our counselling and outreach services. Fundraising and community donations, while a smaller share of overall revenue, fund the parts of our work that fall outside what government contracts cover, and allow us the flexibility to respond quickly when a client needs something a program budget wasn't built for.



Expenses

Every dollar Sage Haven spends is directed toward keeping women, children, and families safe, whether that means staffing our Transition House overnight, running programs at Second Stage Housing, or supporting survivors through counselling and advocacy. The largest share of our expenses goes directly toward program delivery, funded in step with the government and health partnerships that make up most of our revenue. Administration is kept deliberately lean, so that

as much of every dollar as possible reaches the people we serve rather than overhead. Project spending reflects the initiatives and improvements we've undertaken this year, [tie to whatever the "Projects" line specifically funded in 2025-26, e.g. Second Stage build-out costs, program launches, or facility upgrades *needs confirming], while our core partners in health, housing, and public safety continue to fund the day-to-day work that keeps our doors open.



Fiscal Year: April 1, 2025 – March 31, 2026

Donors & Partners

Fundraising Events & Campaigns

Fuel Good Days by Co-op
4th Anniversary Fundraiser –
Foxy Box Wax & Laser Port
Alberni
Anna Maria Gaiga's Annual
Plant Sale
Grace Lutheran Church
Scotiabank Bake Sale

Community Organizations & Businesses

Alberni Valley Community
Foundation
AV Reform Church

Catalyst
Christian Women's Club of PA
Coastal Bridge
CUPE 3479
D'Sign Guy and Gal
John W. Casamave Memorial
Foundation
Leave Her Wild & Colyn's
Plant Donations
No Frills
PA & District Labour Council
PA Toy Run
Phillip & Co CPA
Port Alberni Chinese Society
Port Alberni Port Authority
(PAPO)
Rimrock Gaming Centre

Rotary PA
Royal LePage

Individual Donors

Arlene Alexandrovich
Audrey Barron
Darlene & Donald Barkley
Gillian Shearwater
Joan Watson
John Kuch
Madge Vallee
Crystal Knudsen
Pamela Peaslee
Sandra Hegg
Sunshine Auffrey

Thank You

"This has been one of our most successful years for third-party fundraising. There have been so many fun and creative ways our community has stepped up to support Sage Haven Society, and it's always a pleasure to attend these events. It's a double win for me: I get to have fun, and I get to thank everyone in person for supporting this work."

~ Janine Fraser, Executive Director

MEET OUR

Board of Directors

Our Board of Directors is made up of volunteers from across the Alberni Valley who bring their time, expertise, and lived understanding of this community to the work of guiding Sage Haven. They set the direction of the organization, hold us accountable to our mission, and ensure that the decisions made at a governance level always come back to the people we serve.

Each board member serves as volunteers, alongside their own careers and families, because they believe a safe and inclusive community is worth building together. Their oversight touches everything from financial stewardship to program direction, and their commitment gives Sage Haven the stability to keep showing up for women, children, and families year after year.

Welcome to our 2026/2027 Board Members

Caroline Melville
Chair

Kim Babin
Secretary Treasurer

Hugh Fletcher
Director

Chelsey Belyk
Director

Melissa Gus
Director

A woman with long blonde hair, wearing a floral dress and dark boots, stands in a forest. Behind her is a large, thick, fallen tree trunk. The background is filled with the trunks and branches of many trees, creating a dense forest scene. The entire image has a blue color overlay.

2026-27

Looking Ahead

In the coming year, we're focused on making sure support never has a gap in it, no matter which door someone walks through. That means building relief staffing capacity across our programs, so care continues even when a team member is away, and continuing to shape our services around what the people we serve are actually asking for.

We're strengthening the partnerships that let us respond faster and more completely, from

healthcare and justice partners to fellow community organizations, and deepening trauma-informed, culturally grounded training across every program and every volunteer.

None of this happens without sustained funding and community partnership. As always, our priority stays the same: making sure everyone who reaches out finds somewhere safe to land.



Contact Us

Get in Touch



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